aspirations; in other cases (U Nu's proclamation making Buddhism the official state religion), the cause was perceived religious intolerance. The Kachin Independence Organization was formed at this time with the stated goal being independence. Throughout the modern history of Myanmar, the Kachin insurgency has been the most formidable enemy of the authorities.

For the most part, the Kachin are rice and sugarcane farmers. The insurgent efforts are also funded by the sale of precious gems on the black market. Furthermore, many Kachin work in the forestry and mining industries. The Kachin are involved in cross-border trading, especially with China.

Kayah

Geographically isolated, the Kayah are located in the very remote mountainous region of the Kayah state. No outside travel is allowed in this particular region of Myanmar. Originally animists, the Kayah were partially converted to Christianity by Baptist and Catholic missionaries. The Kayah are sometimes referred to as “Red Karen” because of their brightly colored clothing. As with the Kachin region, the Kayah were granted autonomy via the 1947 constitution with the right of succession following a 10-year period. The Myanmar military implemented a brutal crackdown against the Kayah insurgents, suppressing nationalist aspirations. The infamous “four cuts” strategy implemented by the military led to humanitarian crisis on numerous occasions. Refugee and internally displaced persons (IDP) problems increased as the tatmadaw incursions into the region accelerated. The Kayah are mostly impoverished subsistence-level farmers. Some economic development comes through mining and hydroelectric plants. A significant minority Kayah population lives in Thailand.

Mon

The Mon civilization is one of the oldest in Southeast Asia. Both Buddhism and writing were introduced to Myanmar by the Mon. Mon independence ended following their defeat at the hands of King Alaùngpayà in the 1750s. What remains of the Mon ethnic group is located in the coastal plains region. Following the upheavals on the late 1950s, Mon nationalism emerged. Discrimination against the Mon persisted throughout the early